



“I have lifted my plane... for perhaps a thousand flights and I have never felt her wheels glide from the Earth into the air without knowing the uncertainty and the exhilaration of first-born adventure.”

BERYL MARKHAM

PILOT IN KENYA IN THE 1930S



TINGMISSARTOQ

With this Lockheed Sirius seaplane, Charles Lindbergh and his wife Anne Morrow explored flight routes across both the Pacific and Atlantic Oceans. The aircraft was christened Tingmissartog (meaning “the man who flies like a big bird”) by an Inuit boy in Greenland.

BLAZING THE TRAIL

PILOTS RISKED THEIR LIVES EXPLORING REMOTE PARTS OF THE GLOBE, CROSSING OCEANS, AND PUSHING AIRCRAFT TO THE LIMITS OF SPEED AND ENDURANCE

THE PERIOD between the world wars has often been called the Golden Age of aviation. But the first years after 1918 certainly did not look or feel like the beginning of a Golden Age to either pilots or aircraft manufacturers. The end of World War I was little short of catastrophic for the aircraft-manufacturing business. The market was awash with surplus military aircraft. In the United States, you could buy a Curtiss Jenny trainer for the bargain price of \$300. With demand collapsing, the whole United States aircraft industry manufactured just 328 new aircraft in 1920. In Europe, where aircraft-making capacity had been massively inflated during the war, many manufacturers went bankrupt or turned to other businesses to survive – some made furniture or even pots and pans.

Only a minority of the tens of thousands of military pilots stayed in the army or navy. For those who returned to civilian life still determined to make a living out of flying, the peacetime world offered mostly precarious employment. In Europe, fledgling passenger and airmail services absorbed a number of aircrew. Skywriting, first demonstrated by Major Jack Savage in Britain in 1922 and adopted with

enthusiasm in the United

States, gave some pilots a living as a branch of the burgeoning advertising industry. Other respectable employment for fliers and their airplanes was found in crop dusting, also an innovation of the 1920s, and survey work using aerial photography. Hollywood, which responded to the appeal of aerial adventure with a clutch of movies, had a constant need for stunt pilots. Quite a few World War I fliers – including German ace Ernst Udet – found themselves recreating air combat for the movie cameras.



SOLO PIONEER

Amelia Earhart captured the imagination of America after she became the first woman to complete a solo transatlantic flight in 1932.

The barnstormers

The most prominent role of aviation in the United States was as a fairground sideshow or daredevil circus. At the bottom end of the scale, small groups of “gypsy fliers” toured the remote towns of rural America, putting on a show for local people and taking them up for a ride at a dollar a time. This was life on the breadline. Asked what was the most dangerous thing about his occupation, one gypsy flier in the early 1920s said, “The risk of starving to death.” But at the other extreme, some gifted pilots

